

I wasn't ready to jump from journalism to show business yet, but I quit my job at *Huffington Post* because I had enough name recognition to start freelancing for blogs, magazines, and newspapers full time. That worked for a while until I ran out of money. I applied for full-time work all over and eventually took a job in IT at a women's health magazine. I was as unqualified for this job as I would have been for the Flash animation job in Boston—maybe even more unqualified. I was constantly googling what I needed to do or watching YouTube tutorials to learn. I cried every lunch hour. My bosses were catching on to my being unable to do this job. After much more crying and deliberating and guilt over giving up a good-paying job with health benefits, I quit and went back to the scrappy life of freelancing. I did that for a few months until I landed a gig (lower pay and no health insurance) at a popular millennial feelings dump blog, *Thought Catalog*.

I wrote a million articles for *Thought Catalog* over the year I worked there. It gained me even more of a fan base, but no retirement savings or long-term career guarantees. The turnover rate at all these little start-up blogs was high. I joined Twitter and tweeted my articles, which gained me a following of about 10,000 people. (Not bad.) I ended up leaving *Thought Catalog* to take a better-paying job at the *Daily Dot*, a news blog that also afforded me health insurance. When I look back on my years in NYC, I took no time off and had no hobbies. All my friends were from work. There was no 9-to-5. Work happened all night, every weekend. I can't remember a time when I wasn't working.

My friends never stopped working either. Far from lazy, we were all stressed, overworked, and underpaid. And we could still barely afford to exist.



The first thought people have about my generation, the millennials, is that we're "entitled" or "spoiled." Our mascots are the often tone-deaf Mark Zuckerberg or Hannah Horvath from HBO's *Girls*—out-of-touch rich white liberal arts majors who whine on their iPhones in mommy and daddy's Manhattan pied-à-terre. But those in poverty don't just skip from age 40 to age 3. I identify as a millennial because I was born in 1988, not because I believe we're all alike. For